life. Acutely aware that this was so, Tharoor selects as his subtitle not Ambedkar's "ideas" or "ideology" but his "life". Yet the book's thoroughness seems to eliminate drama and dilute the central passion of Ambedkar's life, which, as Tharoor points out, was the dignity of the humblest.

A second criticism can be about Tharoor's unsafe reliance on stereotypical impressions while addressing a vital question like the comparative constitutional visions of Ambedkar and Gandhi. To suggest, as Tharoor does, that while Ambedkar saw the individual as India's essential unit, Gandhi gave that place to a "romanticised self-reliant village republic" is surely quite unhistorical. Anyone even remotely aware of Gandhi's doings knows that the individual Indian's dignity, and her right not be coerced, was at the heart of his incessant struggle, even as it was at the core of Ambedkar's.

One memorable political event marked by Tharoor occurred in December 1939 when, following the resignation across India of provincial Congress ministries, "Ambedkar joined Jinnah in addressing a heavily attended Day of Deliverance event in a Muslim-dominated locality of Bombay, where each outdid the other in their invective against the Congress Party". Tharoor does not mention it, but the two were soon joined by Periyar E.V. Ramasamy in what proved to be only an evanescent bid to erect an all India anti-Congress alliance.



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The limited nature of Ambedkar's engagement with India's Muslims is a subject neglected by most scholars, and Tharoor is no exception. Ambedkar's detachment vis-à-vis India's Muslims may nonetheless have contributed to the impartiality with which he discussed the Pakistan demand in his *Thoughts on Pakistan*, a book, I might add, that both Gandhi and Jinnah relied upon during their infructuous negotiations in Mumbai in 1944.

With his Bahujan Samaj project, Kanshiram succeeded, three decades or so after Ambedkar's death, in creating a Dalit-Muslim alliance in parts of India. Tharoor's chronicle provokes questions on various subjects of this sort, and some who read this book may feel goaded to pursue their own investigations.

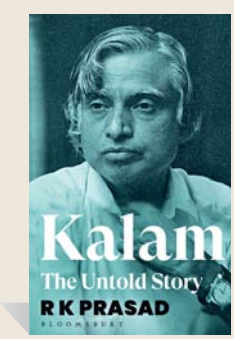
While 'gripping' may not be an apt adjective for this study, I expect it to be widely discussed. And while there may be criticism, most readers will appreciate the book's breadth. And they will agree with Tharoor's conclusion that although Indian society deeply offended Ambedkar's soul, it is with the power of his mind that this astonishing figure continues to influence the thinking of generations. ■

Rajmohan Gandhi's latest book is India After 1947: Reflections & Recollections



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